Benchmark reference answer

Question	Is unemployment rising?
Essential The very minimum an answer needs to include. Comprises: ● Any accurate answer to what the user asked for. ● What the user needs to know in order to avoid being misled.	- Needs to acknowledge that there isn't a definitive yes/no answer given the trend is different depending on the period measured and/or whether the rate or level is being looked at. - Needs to contain some signal that the exact figures are uncertain, either by referencing they are from a survey, or by stating they are uncertain explicitly. **Jun 18th — July 20th** EITHER: The rate is down by 0.3% points on the previous quarter or the rate is down on the prev quarter The rate is up 0.3% points on the previous year. Or the rate is up on the prev year OR: The level is down from the previous quarter (-105,000) The level is up from the previous year (+124,000). **July 21st — Aug 17th** EITHER: The rate is down (by 0.1% points) on the previous quarter but up (0.2% points) on the previous year. OR: Needs to mention that the level is down on the previous quarter (-17,000) but up on the same quarter in the previous year (+81,000). **Aug 18th — Sep 14th** EITHER: Needs to mention that the rate is down by 0.1% points on the previous quarter but up 0.2% points on the previous year. OR: Needs to mention that the level is down on the previous quarter (-36,000) but up from the previous year (+88,000). **Sep 15th — Oct 20th** EITHER: Needs to mention that the rate is largely unchanged on the previous quarter but up 0.2% points on the previous year.

	OR: Needs to mention that the level is up from either the previous quarter (+6,000) or previous year (+82,000).
Good answer If the bare essentials aren't enough to meet an "average" user's needs. Comprises: • Information that further answers the user's question, but that goes beyond what is strictly "essential" *This section is **optional** and is unnecessary for basic questions.*	Acknowledges longer term trend of increasing unemployment rate and level since 2022. Could also mention earlier falls between 2020 and 2022. Unemployment rate is the headline measure, according to the ONS **June 18-20 July** Needs to contain either the current rate (4.9%), or the current level (1.764m), and describe either as for February-April 2026 or March 2026. Mentions the claimant count is rising on both the month and the year. **July 21st — Aug 17th** Needs to contain either the current rate (4.9%), or the current level (1.76m), and describe either as for March-May 2026 (or April 2026). Mentions the claimant count is rising on the month but falling on the year. **Aug 18th — Sep 14th** Needs to contain either the current rate (4.9%), or the current level (1.772m), and describe either as for April-June 2026 (or May 2026). Mentions the claimant count is falling on both the month and the year. **Sep 15th — Oct 20th** Needs to contain either the current rate (4.9%), or the current level (1.778m), and describe either as for May-July 2026 (or June 26). Mentions the claimant count is rising on both the month and the year.
Background Core facts relevant to the question — use as a reference guide for annotators.	All figures are UK-wide. **Jun 18th — July 20th** Unemployment rate: 4.9% (Feb-Apr 2026) Quarterly change: ▼-0.3pps Annual change: ▲ 0.3pps The unemployment rate is up on the year but down on the quarter. 1.764m people unemployed (Feb-Apr 2026) Down from 1.869m on previous quarter (-105,000) Up from 1.64m in same quarter of previous year (+124,000) **July 21st — Aug 17th** Unemployment rate: 4.9% (Mar-May 2026)

	Quarterly change: ▼-0.1pps Annual change: ▲ 0.2pps The unemployment rate is up on the year but down on the quarter. 1.760m people unemployed (Mar-May 2026) Down from 1.777m on previous quarter (-17,000) Up from 1.679m in same quarter of previous year (+81,000) **Aug 18th — Sep 14th** Unemployment rate: 4.9% (Apr-Jun 2026) Quarterly change: ▼-0.1pps Annual change: ▲ 0.2pps The unemployment rate is up on the year but down on the quarter. 1.772m people unemployed (Apr-Jun 2026) Down from 1.808m on previous quarter (-36,000) Up from 1.684m in same quarter of previous year (+88,000) **Sep 15th — Oct 20th** Unemployment rate: 4.9% (May-Jul 2026) Quarterly change: unchanged Annual change: ▲ 0.2pps 1.778m people unemployed (May-Jul 2026) Up from 1.772m on previous quarter (+6,000) Up from 1.696m in same quarter of previous year (+82,000)